



Speakers: Creative SBS 20

Price: Rs 675

Why we chose this: It's a nice pair of desktop speakers that's suitable for listening to music, and for the occasional gaming bit.

Cabinet: Mercury KOB-132

Price: Rs 1,150

Why we chose this: Well, it's a sturdy cabinet, with an extra fan and an option for attaching another one. It has a Micro-ATX form factor that complements the micro-ATX motherboard with three 5.25 expansion bays and one 3.25 expansion bays—roomy enough for even airflow, and the price is just right.

Optical Drive: Samsung 52X CD-ROM

Price: Rs 1,050

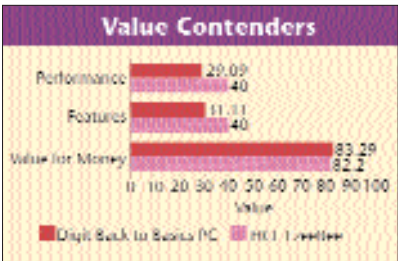
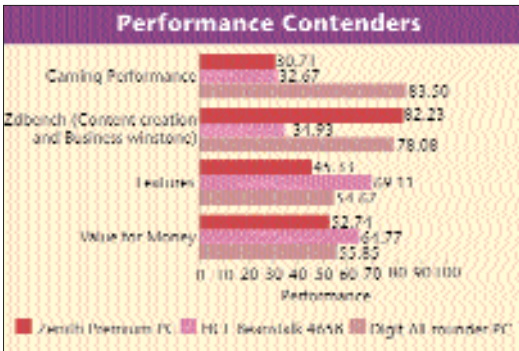
Why we chose this: We chose this basic drive that lets you watch VCDs, listen to MP3 and Audio CDs and also transfer data, because of its low price and high usability.

We used the same modem and floppy drive for this system since they did the job quite well.

Fight, fight!

Once we got our machines up and running, it was time to pit them against the branded masters we were testing.

The competition was tough and the results were mixed—our home-bred PC lead the score in the gaming arena, while HCL packed maximum features and also gave the most value for money. Game, work with multimedia and regular office applications ran



without any issues, and yielded performance, somewhere in between the 2.4 and 3.06 GHz bracket. The graphics accelerator included is one of the best, and is

not even present in the high-end PCs that we received for our tests. We also packed in double the memory and hard disk space than the Rs 51,000 Beantalk. This more than justifies its price, which amounts to Rs 60,510.

A similar scenario emerged when we compared our Back to Basics PC with similarly configured entrants. Its performance was equivalent to the PCS Pentium 4 1.7 GHz system. Though not the best performer, it does enough to keep you happy at Rs 20,685.

Our home-assembled systems performed well, and gave the branded entrants a run for their money—something that did us proud! ■

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